

After Tooth Extraction

Simple after-care instructions to support comfortable healing

WHAT IS NORMAL?

Mild pain, tenderness, slight swelling and a small amount of blood-stained saliva can be normal after an extraction. Swelling may increase during the first 2–3 days before gradually improving.

REMEMBER

The blood clot in the extraction socket is important for healing. Protect it and avoid anything that may dislodge it.

1. For the first 24 hours

- Keep the gauze in place for the time advised by your dentist and apply gentle, steady pressure.
- Do not repeatedly spit, rinse forcefully or disturb the extraction socket.
- Avoid smoking or vaping and avoid alcohol during the initial healing period.
- Rest and avoid strenuous exercise for the first day, or as advised.

2. Eating and drinking

- Wait until the local anaesthetic has worn off before eating so you do not bite your cheek, lip or tongue.
- Choose soft, cool or lukewarm foods initially and chew on the opposite side.
- Avoid very hot foods and drinks while the area is numb.
- Do not use a straw during the early healing period, as suction may disturb the blood clot.

3. Brushing and rinsing

- Continue brushing the other teeth gently, taking care not to disturb the extraction site.
- Do not vigorously rinse the mouth during the first 24 hours.
- After the first 24 hours, gentle warm salt-water rinses may be advised by your dentist. Do not swish forcefully.

4. Pain and swelling

- Use pain-relieving medication only as advised by your dentist/doctor and according to the medication instructions.
- An ice pack wrapped in a cloth can be applied to the outside of the cheek for short periods during the first day to help reduce swelling.
- Some swelling and discomfort can be expected, but they should gradually improve.

5. Protect the healing socket

- **Do not pick, touch or probe the socket** with your finger, tongue or any object.
- Avoid smoking/vaping because it can interfere with healing and increase the risk of complications.
- Keep the area clean according to your dentist's instructions.

6. When should you contact us?

- **Contact your dentist promptly if you develop:**
- Bleeding that does not settle despite firm pressure
- Severe or worsening pain, especially pain that becomes stronger after a few days
- Significant or increasing swelling
- Fever, pus, foul taste or persistent bad smell
- Difficulty opening the mouth, swallowing or breathing — **seek urgent medical/dental care.**

Important: These are general patient-education instructions and do not replace personalised advice from your treating dentist. Instructions may differ depending on the type and difficulty of extraction and your medical history.

References

1. American Dental Association. Oral Health Topics: Tooth Extractions. Patient information.
2. American Association of Oral and Maxillofacial Surgeons. Post-Operative Instructions: After Tooth Extraction. Patient information.
3. National Health Service (NHS). Tooth removal: recovery and aftercare. Patient information.